An Overview of Ethics

Course: Professional Practices

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What is Ethics?

- **Ethics** is the study of what is *right and wrong*, *good and bad*, *fair and unfair* in human conduct. It explores moral principles that guide behavior.
- In computing: ethics guides decisions about technology design, data, privacy, and fairness.
- **THE TECH ANALOGY:** Think of Ethics as the Operating System for human behavior. *Laws, policies, and regulations are just the "apps" running on top. If the OS is buggy, the apps will crash.*

Why Does Ethics Matter?

- Ethics builds **trust**, **credibility**, and **social acceptance** of technology.
- It helps prevent harm and promotes fairness.
- Professionals are judged not only by skills, but by moral choices.
- In Computing Context: Responsible data handling, avoiding bias, preventing misuse of technology.
- The Cost of Ethical Failure?
  - User Trust, Reputation, Legal Risks

A Brief History: Ethics and Humanity

- **Ancient Roots**: Code of Hammurabi (1750 BCE), Socratic ethics (400 BCE), Confucius' "Golden Mean".
- **Religious and Cultural Ethics**: Buddhism, Christianity, Islam, and others developed moral codes.
- **Modern Era**: From Kant's categorical imperative to Mill's utilitarianism.
- **Today**: Applied ethics; fields like bioethics, AI ethics, and computer ethics.

Humans have always searched for ways to live well together; technology just gives it new shapes.

Integrity: The Core of Ethics

- **Integrity** = **consistency** between one's values, decisions, and actions.
- Doing the right thing even when no one is watching.
- Example (Computing): Reporting a discovered vulnerability rather than exploiting it. Giving credit for open-source code used.
- **Analogy**: Integrity is like data integrity; if values are altered unnoticed, the whole system becomes unreliable.

Ethics vs. Law

Aspect	⚖ Law	♥ Ethics
Definition	A system of rules created and enforced by governmental authorities	Moral principles that govern behavior and decision-making
Enforcement	External enforcement through legal system, courts, and penalties	Internal enforcement through conscience, professional standards, and social pressure
Scope	Defines minimum acceptable standards of behavior	Aspires to higher standards of conduct and responsibility
Flexibility	Rigid, slow to change, requires legislative process	Dynamic, adaptable to new situations and technologies
Consequences	Legal penalties: fines, imprisonment, civil liability	Professional consequences: loss of trust, reputation damage, career impact
Technology Relevance	Often lags behind technological advances	Can address emerging issues immediately

Ethics vs. Law (Cont'd)

- **Critical Understanding:** The ethical obligations of computing professionals go beyond complying with laws or regulations; laws often lag behind advances in technology.
- "Just because something is legal doesn't make it ethical. And just because something is illegal doesn't make it unethical."
- **The Gray Area**: Many technology practices are legal but raise serious ethical concerns. These actions exploit loopholes, prioritize profit over user welfare, or manipulate users in ways that are technically permitted but morally questionable.

Examples of Ethical – Legal Conflicts

Unethical but Legal:

- Harvesting user data without clear consent, tracking users across platforms, difficult cancellation processes, forced opt-ins, biased hiring algorithms etc.

Ethical but Illegal:

- Whistleblowing on harmful corporate practices, civil disobedience, breaking patents for public health

Key Question: For employees who observe misconduct, the dilemma is stark: Remain silent and complicit, or report the wrongdoing and risk retaliation?

The Golden Rule: The Core Ethic of Reciprocity

“Treat others as you want to be treated.”

The Golden Rule Across World Religions:

- Do unto others as you would have them do unto you.” Matthew 7:12
- "None of you truly believes until he loves for his brother what he loves for himself.” Sahih Bukhari
- "Whatever is disagreeable to yourself, do not do unto others.” Buddha
- "This is the sum of duty: do not do to others what would cause pain if done to you.” Mahabharata 5:1517

The Golden Rule (Cont’d)

Application in Computing:

- Design systems that respect user dignity and autonomy.
- If you wouldn’t want your data used without consent, don’t do it to others.

While the Golden Rule sounds simple, its application in professional computing practice faces several significant challenges.

Why does practicing "The Golden Rule" (Treat others as you would like to be treated) only work with some people and not others?

Implementation Challenges

- **Abstract vs. Concrete**: Universal rules (e.g., "be fair") are ambiguous in specific coding contexts.
- **Diverse Perspectives**: Global users have conflicting cultural values regarding privacy and speech.
- **Conflicting Interests**: Stakeholder trade-offs (e.g., User Privacy vs. Company Profit vs. National Security).
- **Information Asymmetry**: Developers know how the system works; users often don't understand the risks.
- **Short-term vs. Long-term**: Immediate pressure to "ship it" conflicts with long-term societal impact analysis.

Solutions and Best Practices

The Platinum Rule

"Treat others as THEY want to be treated"

- Actively listen and learn about stakeholder needs
- Conduct user research and testing
- Create diverse, inclusive teams
- Implement feedback mechanisms
- Some ways for managers to implement the Golden Rule involve being mindful of when and how to apply it